artistic practices, and architectural evolutions of the border. The chapter ends by exploring Tajiri's multiple approaches to documenting the Wall, including film and varied images practices. Ultimately, Tajiri's long-standing project of approaching the Wall emphasizes the way his methods of geopolitical exploration and visual excavation were connected rites for the artist. In particular, his recurrent focus on the border signage of the American sector brings his experience as an expatriate artist and soldier in relation to the ripple effects of U.S. militarism. American artists, like their colleagues in Europe and elsewhere, reconsidered the scope and scale of the Wall as an artistic and geopolitical dilemma: to attempt to reconcile strategies of confronting the border's pernicious state while at the same time approaching the border as a venue for artistic inquiry and exploration.

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The Berlin Wall's first major renovation coincided with an emergent status quo in which the divided city's Cold War status evolved further from potential battleground to site of simmering tension. In its early days, Berlin's division seemed to position the city on the brink of a global battle. Despite the later period of Cold War diplomacy and East-West acknowledgment, American presence in Berlin was nonetheless volatile. The American occupation of Germany officially ended in 1955, but the U.S. military presence continued there through the Cold War. Following a high point in American–West German relations in the early 1960s, the escalating conflict in Vietnam and the rise of student movement protests in West Germany led to a fraying of identification with the legacy of the Americans as liberators. Martin Klimke notes, "The U.S. government's prestige began to change among the perceptions [of] the young generation both in the United States and Europe. … The notion that the United States, once seen as a democratic model, guiding spirit, and leader of the supposed 'free world,' was waging an ever-escalating and questionable war in Southeast Asia led many to revolt against what they believed to be a cynical version of democracy."[16]

Opposition in West Berlin to unchecked American military power occurred alongside grassroots global uprisings in Paris, Prague, Mexico City, Chicago, and other cities. In West Berlin, in 1965, the first prominent Vietnam War protestors gathered and threw eggs outside the Amerika Haus, a building designed for cultural exchange through state-sponsored cultural diplomacy. In 1967, dissenters amped up their pushback as several activists